



A podium finish: Anantjeet Singh Naruka celebrates after winning the bronze medal in the skeet men's final at the ISSF World Cup Final in New Delhi. PTI

shooters taking part in the Olympic pistol and rifle events, compared to 2,622 at the 2019 edition. This trend is expected to continue at the Nationals in New Delhi/Bhopal.

However, challenges remain. "If not properly planned, these numbers won't mean much. *Mela lagane mein aur ladai karne mein farak hai* (there's a difference between just getting numbers and preparing for a battle)," says Jaspal Rana, Manu's coach. According to Rana, there needs to be a systematic timeline set for athletes. "You can't prepare for an exam if you don't know when it's supposed to be held. I would like to see the schedule for the selection trials announced well in advance and

not changed once it's decided," he states.

The National Rifle Association of India (NRAI), for its part, asserts that it will provide a detailed selection policy and schedule, along with a review of the previous Olympic cycle.

"We may have had our best Olympic cycle, but we are conducting a systematic review of how we prepared for the Paris Games. There are areas for improvement, and we will be making a report on that," says Kalikesh Deo, president of the NRAI. However, he notes that drafting a selection policy will be more challenging since the ISSF

(International Shooting Sport Federation) has announced that it will likely change the format of multiple events. ISSF president Luciano Rossi informed Sportstar that this process would be completed ahead of the 2026 World Championships — the first selection competition for the 2028 Olympics. "It would make sense to draft a selection process for the Olympics only once we know what the competition format looks like," Deo explains.

Rana hopes that greater freedom will be accorded to individual shooters to determine their own training systems. "During the current

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